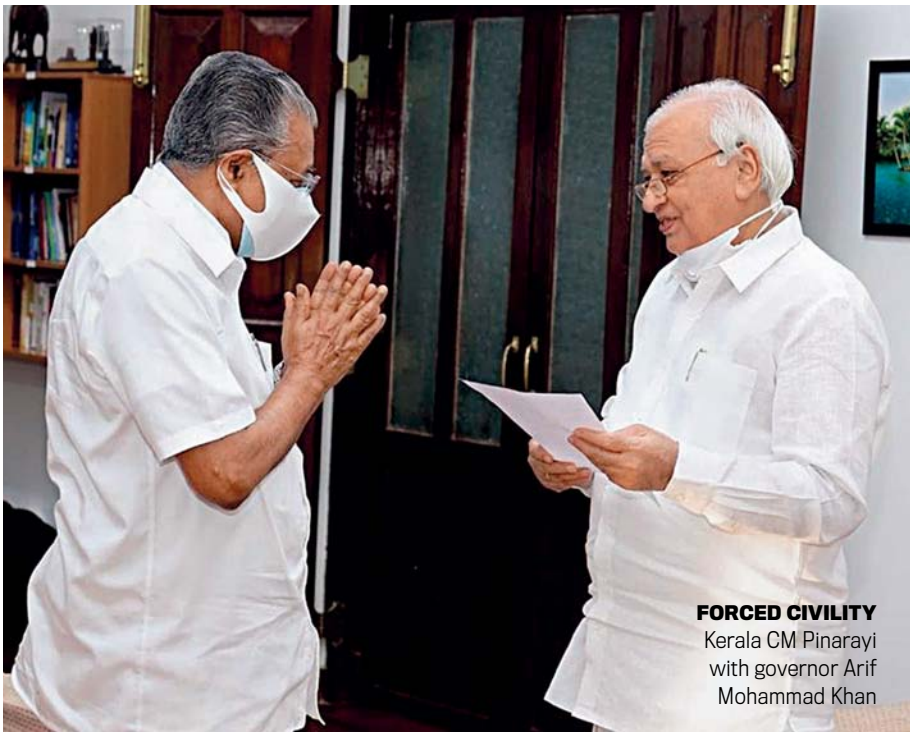
opposed to OPS, though he has made no public statement yet. His opposition on another issue—10 per cent quota for the Economically Weaker Section (EWS)—recently forced the Congress to alter its stand. When the Supreme Court, on November 7, upheld the constitutional validity of the amendment brought by the Narendra Modi government to implement that quota, the Congress initially welcomed it. Ramesh said the amendment was the result of a process the Manmohan-led UPA government had initiated in 2005-6. Gehlot too chipped in, saying, "This will help the poor get justice." In contrast, both Chidambaram, and his Lok Sabha MP-son Karthi, questioned the judgment. Another Tamil Nadu MP, S. Jothimani, echoed them. Then Ramesh, on November 11, said the party was doing a "deep think" on the SC verdict.

The relative lack of cohesion among the juniors also owes to the variable patronage of seniors. A certain fear has taken root after the exit of young turks like Scindia, Jitin Prasada, R.P.N. Singh and Sushmita Dev. Once seen as core members of the team around Rahul, electoral compulsions and their failure to negotiate the intrigues of the seniors forced them to quit. "If those backed by Rahul did not stand a chance, why ask about others? Nor can the Gandhis afford to upset the apple cart as they need the financial clout of the seniors to fight polls or organise events such as the Udaipur Chintan Shivir or the Bharat Jodo Yatra," says a Rajya Sabha MP. It was not without reason that the shivir was held in Rajasthan or Gehlot has been made Gujarat and Chhattisgarh poll in-charge. "Money speaks louder than performance and popularity," says a former CM. That's what keeps the Congress trapped in the vicious cycle of patronage politics. ■



ANI

**FORCED CIVILITY**
Kerala CM Pinarayi with governor Arif Mohammad Khan

KERALA

# STATUTORY TIFF

**By Jeemon Jacob**

There seems to be no let-up in the mortal combat between the governor and the chief minister in God's own country. Kerala governor Arif Mohammad Khan was in New Delhi when the ruling Left Democratic Front mounted a mega protest under the banner of the 'Education Protection Forum' outside the Raj Bhavan in Thiruvananthapuram against what it called Khan's attempts to "saffronise educational institutions" in the state. Khan watched on television as CPI(M) general secretary Sitaram Yechury inaugurated the protests, calling it a people's movement against a governor trying to execute a right-wing political agenda.

"Kerala is the only state where an individual is treated like a human being and not on the basis of caste or religion," Yechury said. "The BJP is trying to destroy Kerala's unique identity and we will fight the dark forces with undying spirit."

The CPI(M) is making common cause with other Opposition parties that are similarly resisting the BJP's efforts to destabilise non-BJP governments through governors asserting their constitutional authority over elected governments. The battle in Kerala itself has been going on for nearly a year, with Khan taking on the Pinarayi Vijayan government on a number of issues. Those run a controversial gamut, from smuggling onward, but the prize fight is over what Khan calls "nepotism" in the appointment of vice-chancellors to universities in the state.

Neither Pinarayi nor his cabinet ministers were personally present at the protest meet. Joining the cause instead was the M.K. Stalin-led DMK government in Tamil Nadu, which sent Rajya Sabha MP Tiruchi Siva to address the protesters. Extending his party's support, Siva modified the protest march slogan 'Mr Khan, you are wrong. This is Kerala' by adding: 'This is South